



COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY
IN THE CITY OF NEW YORK

Sammy Abdella

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345 W 86th Street, New York, NY, 10024

Dear Mr. Ghodsi,

It's a genuine honor to reach out to you, especially through Mrs. Jane Sun, to whom I'm grateful for the care she has shown me. As you once said, "People don't want to leave their home country, but sometimes staying becomes untenable, and they eventually have to flee."

At age 18, I was facing the death penalty after my parents outed me as gay, which is criminalized in Tunisia. While I was homeless and a fugitive, I worked as a server and cleaned bathrooms to afford library access. I used that access to teach myself English so I could write my college applications and submit them through public library computers, which earned me admission to Columbia University. I escaped to the United States as an international student with only the clothes on my back, and in a month, I will graduate from Columbia University with a Bachelor's degree in Computer Science.

You have spoken candidly about fleeing the Iranian revolution, and I deeply relate, especially because I lived through the Tunisian revolution that sparked the Arab Spring. Your perseverance, not only surviving what you were forced to flee, but thriving in the field you pursued, and ultimately chasing the American dream by democratizing data and AI, has been a profound source of inspiration to me. Along that same thread of opportunity, at the Columbia University AI Laboratory, I was able to lead the development of gAyI, an AI tool for LGBTQ mental health support, with published outcomes that reflect what you champion about democratizing data and AI and that technology should widen access responsibly and reach

people at every level. In my case, it was a way of democratizing support for people who cannot safely ask for help.

With years of experience including research and internships at YC funded companies, I'm ready to devote my life to Databricks' mission and to building systems that are worthy of the trust people place in them. However, at this moment, my biggest barrier isn't ambition or readiness. It's my immigration status and the need for H1B sponsorship. I'm unable to renew my Tunisian passport due to my persecution in Tunisia, and asylum cases in the USA are currently frozen indefinitely. Therefore, my last hope remains to stay in the USA, as my departure would forfeit my right to return.

If given an opportunity at Databricks, I will honor it with the same perseverance that carried me from surviving on the streets of Tunisia to graduating from Columbia University in New York.

With utmost respect and gratitude,

Sam Nawaly Abdella

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EDUCATION

Columbia University in The City of New York

B.S. Computer Science

SKILLS

Technical: Python, Git, Linux, REST, PostgreSQL, C++, Java, JavaScript, SQL, HTML/CSS, Ruby, OAuth2, JWT, Docker, Kubernetes

Languages: French, Arabic, English

EXPERIENCE

Web Developer Intern | Columbia College IT Dept | New York, NY

08/2025 – Present

- Migrated 43 Columbia departmental websites from Drupal 7 to Drupal 10, writing migration scripts, refactoring custom modules, building/refreshing site themes with HTML/CSS, running regression tests, improving average page load times by ~35%, and removing 100% of deprecated modules in production
- Integrated a Django, PostgreSQL, and RESTful API backend with a new Columbia admissions website, scaling reliably to 50,000+ applicants per cycle, cutting form submission errors by ~40%, and reducing manual data correction work by ~50%

Backend Software Developer Intern | Casca | Remote

06/2024 – 09/2024

- Built async webhook pipeline with Celery/Redis, reducing settlement processing lag ~25% and cutting duplicate payout incidents by 70% through idempotency and retry controls
- Implemented OpenTelemetry tracing and structured logging across services; shortened incident triage time ~30% and improved root-cause identification during outages for on-call engineers
- Strengthened transaction services with RBAC, audit trails, and secrets rotation; reduced unauthorized-access alerts ~15%, improved audit readiness, and made large deployments more reliable under peak traffic

Research Intern | Columbia University AI Laboratory | New York, NY

01/2025 – 09/2025

- Led the development for gAyl, an AI tool for LGBTQ+ suicide prevention, designed six model-based safety benchmarks to generate treatment plan recommendations and achieved <15% false-negative rate on unsafe-response detection across 1,000+ high-risk prompts
- Trained LLM-based classifiers in PyTorch and Hugging Face Transformers to automate safety evaluation, reducing manual benchmarking time by ~95%
- Publication (co-author): <https://doi.org/10.7916/z6vc-d867>

Software Engineer Intern | Compyle.ai | Remote

05/2025 – Present

- Added Sentry error monitoring and alerts for the summarization/Q&A pipeline; reduced time-to-detect production errors by ~60% and cut repeat-user failure reports by ~20%
- Implemented request throttling and caching for LLM calls using Redis; reduced average LLM API requests per user session by ~30% and lowered latency spikes during peak usage

Projects

AI-Powered Exam Tutor | Python, Django, PostgreSQL, Redis, Celery, Docker

09/2025 – 01/2026

- Built a web app that generates timed practice exams, stores attempts, and produces graded reports with explanations and targeted remediation suggestions
- Deployed with Columbia University's Learning Center to support 50+ students across Data Structures, Advanced Programming, and Multivariable Calculus exam prep